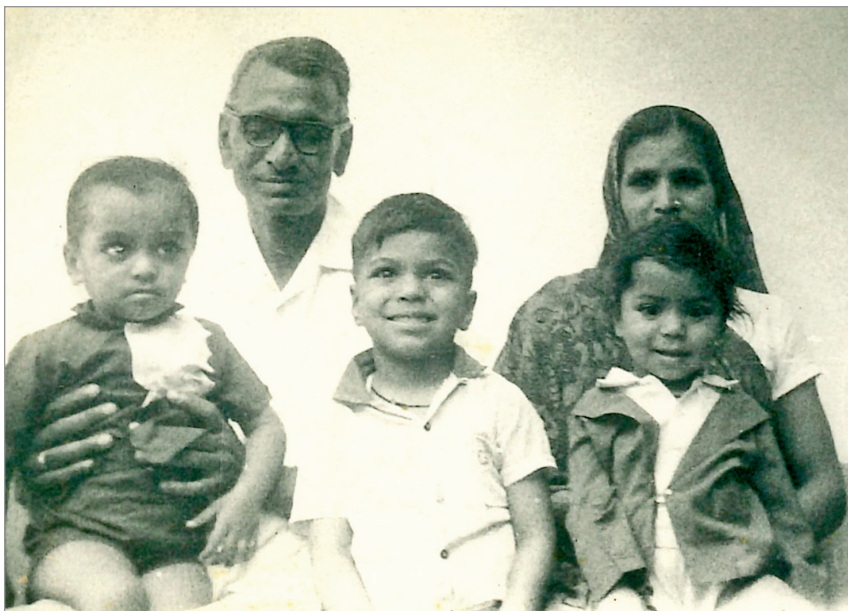




Rajat Moona (in centre) with his grandparents and siblings

Growing up in a house with seven children, Rajat learned early the value of sharing—be it books, toys, or clothes. This sense of tolerance served him well when he later moved into a hostel at IIT Kanpur to pursue electrical engineering.

At the time, electrical engineering was considered a highly prestigious field, and gaining admission to an IIT was a monumental achievement. One might imagine that in a lively household filled with children, the urge to neglect studies and play would be strong. However, the disciplined atmosphere cultivated by his family, with its structured timetable of study and play, kept all the children focused. A healthy, unspoken competition between the siblings spurred them to constantly improve. “Things like racing to see who could pack their school bag first became a playful contest. Though we were never explicitly told to hurry, there was always a drive to be first. This fostered a productive environment for concentration and made my childhood very enjoyable,” he reflects.

The linguistic battle

As smooth as Rajat’s childhood was, his college life came with its own challenges. Upon stepping into the gates of IIT Kanpur, he witnessed a significant change in the environment. The teachers, tutors, and office staff—all communicated fluently in English, which was the

primary mode of interaction.

For someone who had studied in a Hindi-medium school in Uttar Pradesh, conversing with his educators was difficult. “We spoke pure and polished Hindi. For instance, I would refer to school as *vidyalaya*. On entering IIT, everything changed. While we had studied English in school, it wasn’t the primary mode of communication. At one point, during my first year, things got so tough that a few of us, including me, contemplated leaving the institution. We figured that this wasn’t our cup of tea, and it would be better to leave,” shares Rajat.

There are no points for guessing that a plot twist was on the way, because had Rajat left the institution then, his story would not have been told. A certain friend, Pawan Kumar, came to the rescue. Pawan had secured rank three in the engineering entrance exam nationwide and was one of the sharpest in the batch. Despite a relative grading system, where an individual’s grades were influenced by the performance of others, Pawan was a



Rajat Moona at the back with his siblings and parents